DEFENCE JOURNEY

NDA History Notes

Ancient, medieval, modern India, freedom movement and world history

NDA | HISTORY

History in NDA covers Indian history from ancient times to Independence, the freedom movement, and important world events. Dates, names of rulers and the cause of important events are asked most often.

1. Ancient India

Period	Key points
Stone Age	Paleolithic, Mesolithic (microliths), Neolithic (farming, pottery). Bhimbetka rock shelters (Madhya Pradesh) have cave paintings.
Indus Valley Civilisation (about 2600 to 1900 BCE)	Sites: Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Lothal (dockyard), Dholavira, Kalibangan, Rakhigarhi. Town planning with grid streets, drainage, Great Bath. Traders used seals and weights. The script is still not deciphered.
Vedic Age	Early Vedic (Rigveda, about 1500 to 1000 BCE) and Later Vedic. Four Vedas: Rig, Sama, Yajur, Atharva. Upanishads, Epics (Ramayana, Mahabharata).
Mahajanapadas (6th century BCE)	16 kingdoms; Magadha became the most powerful. Buddhism and Jainism arose.
Buddha and Mahavira	Buddha: born at Lumbini, enlightenment at Bodh Gaya, first sermon at Sarnath, died at Kushinagar. Teachings: Four Noble Truths, Eightfold Path. Mahavira: 24th Tirthankara of Jainism; teachings of non-violence.
Persian and Greek invasions	Alexander invaded in 326 BCE and defeated Porus at the Battle of the Hydaspes (Jhelum).

Empires

Dynasty	Important rulers and facts
Mauryan (321 to 185 BCE)	Chandragupta Maurya founded it with Chanakya (Kautilya, author of Arthashastra). Bindusara. **Ashoka**: Kalinga war (261 BCE), became a Buddhist, rock and pillar edicts in Brahmi, spread Dhamma. Megasthenes (Indica) visited the court of Chandragupta. Sarnath Lion Capital is India's national emblem.
Kushana	Kanishka: patron of Buddhism, Gandhara art, 4th Buddhist Council, started the Shaka era (78 CE).
Gupta (about 320 to 550 CE)	Golden Age. Chandragupta I, **Samudragupta** (Napoleon of India), **Chandragupta II Vikramaditya** (Navratnas, Kalidasa). Fa-Hien visited. Aryabhata (astronomy, zero), Nalanda University.
Harsha (606 to 647 CE)	Capital Kannauj. Hiuen Tsang (Chinese traveller) visited. Wrote Ratnavali. Defeated by Pulakeshin II of the Chalukyas.
South India	Sangam age (Chera, Chola, Pandya). Pallavas (Mahabalipuram). Chalukyas (Badami, Aihole). **Cholas**: Rajaraja I built the Brihadeeswara temple at Thanjavur; Rajendra I had a strong navy.

2. Medieval India

Period	Key points
Early invasions	Muhammad bin Qasim (Sindh, 712 CE). Mahmud of Ghazni (raided 17 times, Somnath 1025). Muhammad Ghori defeated Prithviraj Chauhan in the Second Battle of Tarain (1192).
Delhi Sultanate (1206 to 1526)	Five dynasties: Slave, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid, Lodi. **Qutb-ud-din Aibak** began the Slave dynasty and the Qutub Minar. **Iltutmish** consolidated it. **Razia Sultana** was the first woman ruler. **Alauddin Khalji**: market reforms, large army. **Muhammad bin Tughlaq**: shifted capital to Daulatabad, token currency. **Firoz Shah Tughlaq**: canals. Ibrahim Lodi lost to Babur.
Vijayanagara and Bahmani	Vijayanagara Empire (1336, Harihara and Bukka); the greatest ruler was Krishnadevaraya (Hampi). Battle of Talikota (1565) ended it. Bahmani kingdom (1347).
Bhakti and Sufi movements	Saints: Kabir, Guru Nanak (Sikhism), Mirabai, Tulsidas, Surdas, Chaitanya, Ramananda, Namdev. Sufi saints: Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti (Ajmer), Nizamuddin Auliya. Amir Khusro (poet).

Mughal Empire

Ruler	Facts
Babur (1526 to 1530)	Won the First Battle of Panipat (1526) against Ibrahim Lodi, and the Battle of Khanwa (1527) against Rana Sanga. Wrote Baburnama.
Humayun (1530 to 1556)	Lost to Sher Shah Suri at Chausa (1539) and Kannauj (1540). Regained the throne in 1555.
Sher Shah Suri (1540 to 1545)	Built the Grand Trunk Road, introduced the silver rupee, and a good revenue system.
Akbar (1556 to 1605)	Second Battle of Panipat (1556). Policy of Sulh-i-kul, Din-i-Ilahi, Mansabdari system, Todar Mal's land revenue. Navratnas, Fatehpur Sikri, Buland Darwaza. Battle of Haldighati (1576) against Maharana Pratap.
Jahangir (1605 to 1627)	Chain of Justice. Nur Jahan's influence. Paintings flourished.
Shah Jahan (1628 to 1658)	Built the Taj Mahal, Red Fort, Jama Masjid (Delhi). Golden age of Mughal architecture.
Aurangzeb (1658 to 1707)	Expanded the empire to its greatest extent, reimposed jizya. Long Deccan wars. After him the empire declined.
Marathas	**Shivaji** was crowned at Raigad in 1674. Administration by Ashta Pradhan. Third Battle of Panipat (1761): Marathas lost to Ahmad Shah Abdali.

3. Modern India

Year	Event
1498	Vasco da Gama reached Calicut.
1600	East India Company formed.
1757	Battle of Plassey: Robert Clive defeated Siraj-ud-Daulah. British power began in India.
1764	Battle of Buxar. Treaty of Allahabad (1765) gave the Company the Diwani rights of Bengal.
1829	Sati abolished by Lord William Bentinck (with Raja Ram Mohan Roy's efforts).
1853	First railway line, Bombay to Thane.
1856	Widow Remarriage Act (Vidyasagar's efforts).
1857	The Revolt (First War of Independence) began at Meerut on 10 May. Leaders: Rani Lakshmibai (Jhansi), Tatya Tope, Nana Sahib, Bahadur Shah Zafar, Kunwar Singh, Begum Hazrat Mahal.
1858	Government of India Act: rule passed to the British Crown. Lord Canning became the first Viceroy.
1885	Indian National Congress founded (A. O. Hume). First president: W. C. Bonnerjee.
1905	Partition of Bengal (Lord Curzon). Swadeshi movement began. Annulled in 1911.
1906	All India Muslim League founded at Dhaka.
1911	Capital shifted from Calcutta to Delhi.
1915	Gandhi returned from South Africa.
1916	Lucknow Pact between the Congress and the League. Home Rule Leagues (Tilak and Annie Besant).
1917 and 1918	Champaran Satyagraha (1917), Ahmedabad mill strike and Kheda (1918).
1919	Rowlatt Act. **Jallianwala Bagh massacre** (13 April, Amritsar, General Dyer).
1920 to 1922	Non-Cooperation Movement. Called off after the Chauri Chaura incident (Feb 1922).
1928	Simon Commission boycotted. Lala Lajpat Rai died after a lathi charge.
1929	Lahore Congress (Nehru): demand for Purna Swaraj. Bhagat Singh threw bombs in the Assembly.
1930	**Civil Disobedience Movement**. Dandi March (12 March to 6 April) against the salt law.
1931	Gandhi-Irwin Pact. Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev hanged. Second Round Table Conference.
1932	Communal Award and Poona Pact (Gandhi and Ambedkar).
1935	Government of India Act, 1935.
1942	Cripps Mission. **Quit India Movement** (8 August, Bombay): "Do or Die".
1943 to 1945	Subhas Chandra Bose led the Azad Hind Fauj (INA) with the slogan "Delhi Chalo". Formed the Provisional Government at Singapore (1943).
1946	Cabinet Mission. Interim government. Royal Indian Navy revolt.
1947	Mountbatten Plan (3 June). Independence Act. **India became free on 15 August 1947.** Mountbatten was the last Viceroy and became the first Governor-General of free India.

Year	Event
1948	Mahatma Gandhi assassinated on 30 January. C. Rajagopalachari was the last and only Indian Governor-General.
1950	The Constitution came into force on 26 January (Republic Day).

Social reformers

Person	Contribution
Raja Ram Mohan Roy	Founded the Brahmo Samaj (1828). Against sati. Called the father of the Indian Renaissance.
Dayananda Saraswati	Arya Samaj (1875). Slogan: "Go back to the Vedas".
Swami Vivekananda	Ramakrishna Mission (1897). Spoke at the Parliament of Religions, Chicago (1893).
Jyotiba Phule	Satyashodhak Samaj. Worked for the education of women and the lower castes.
Sir Syed Ahmad Khan	Founded the Aligarh Movement and the Muhammadan Anglo-Oriental College (Aligarh).
Ishwar Chandra Vidyasagar	Campaigned for widow remarriage and women's education.

Important leaders and their titles

Leader	Known as / fact
Mahatma Gandhi	Father of the Nation. Books: Hind Swaraj. Newspapers: Young India, Harijan.
Jawaharlal Nehru	First Prime Minister of India (1947 to 1964).
Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel	Iron Man of India. Integrated the princely states. Statue of Unity in Gujarat.
Subhas Chandra Bose	Netaji. Formed the Forward Bloc and the INA. Slogan: "Give me blood, I will give you freedom".
Bal Gangadhar Tilak	"Swaraj is my birthright and I shall have it." Newspapers: Kesari, Mahratta.
Gopal Krishna Gokhale	Political guru of Gandhi. Founded the Servants of India Society.
Lala Lajpat Rai	Punjab Kesari.
Dr. B. R. Ambedkar	Chairman of the Drafting Committee of the Constitution. First Law Minister.
Dr. Rajendra Prasad	President of the Constituent Assembly and first President of India (1950 to 1962).

4. World History

Event	Key facts
Renaissance (14th to 17th century)	Began in Italy. Leonardo da Vinci (Mona Lisa), Michelangelo, Galileo, Copernicus. Printing press by Gutenberg (about 1440).
Reformation (1517)	Martin Luther protested against the Church.
American Revolution	American Declaration of Independence on 4 July 1776. George Washington was the first President.
French Revolution (1789)	Fall of the Bastille on 14 July 1789. Slogan: Liberty, Equality, Fraternity. Led to the rise of Napoleon Bonaparte, defeated at Waterloo (1815).
Industrial Revolution	Began in Britain in the 18th century. Spinning jenny (Hargreaves), steam engine (James Watt), power loom.
Russian Revolution (1917)	Led by Lenin (Bolsheviks). The Tsar was overthrown. The USSR was formed in 1922.
World War I (1914 to 1918)	Allies (Britain, France, Russia, USA) versus Central Powers (Germany, Austria-Hungary, Turkey). Triggered by the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand. Treaty of Versailles (1919). League of Nations (1920).
World War II (1939 to 1945)	Began with Germany's attack on Poland (1 Sept 1939). Axis (Germany, Italy, Japan) versus Allies. Pearl Harbor (Dec 1941). Atom bombs on Hiroshima (6 Aug) and Nagasaki (9 Aug 1945). The United Nations was set up on 24 October 1945.
Cold War	Rivalry between the USA and the USSR. NATO (1949) versus the Warsaw Pact (1955). The Berlin Wall fell in 1989 and the USSR broke up in 1991.
Chinese Revolution	The People's Republic of China was formed in 1949 under Mao Zedong.

5. Basics of the Indian Constitution

- The Constituent Assembly first met on 9 December 1946. The Constitution was adopted on **26 November 1949** and came into force on **26 January 1950**.
- It originally had 395 articles, 22 parts and 8 schedules (now 12 schedules). Drafting Committee chairman: Dr. B. R. Ambedkar.
- **Fundamental Rights** (Articles 12 to 35): Equality, Freedom, Against Exploitation, Freedom of Religion, Cultural and Educational Rights, Constitutional Remedies. Right to Property is no longer a Fundamental Right.
- **Directive Principles** are in Part IV. **Fundamental Duties** were added by the 42nd Amendment (1976).
- The President is elected indirectly. Parliament has the Lok Sabha (lower house), Rajya Sabha (upper house) and the President. The Prime Minister heads the Council of Ministers.
- Minimum age: Lok Sabha member 25, Rajya Sabha member 30, President 35. Voting age is 18 years.

TIP: Make a timeline of 40 key dates on one sheet and revise it every week. Match events with persons and places.